



Minerals from the oceans

Oceans are an important source of useful minerals. These minerals range from the sand and gravel needed for the construction industry, to incredibly valuable diamonds. Some minerals have been harvested for centuries. Others, however, are found in much deeper parts of the ocean and there is still no way of retrieving them without spending more than the minerals are worth.

SEA SALT

For hundreds of years, people living near the seashore have turned salty ocean water into edible sea salt. The water is let into shallow pools called salt pans, which dry out under the Sun. As the water evaporates, it leaves the salt crystals behind. These can then be heaped up and shoveled into sacks. This simple industry is still important to many coastal communities.

▼ SALT PAN WORKERS

Rubber boots and gloves protect the skin of these salt gatherers on the coast of Vietnam.



DESALINATION

The salt in seawater makes it undrinkable. But the salt can be removed to obtain fresh water—a process called desalination. It uses a lot of energy, but this is not a problem for the oil-rich desert states of the Middle East, where it is often the only source of fresh water. This aerial view shows one of these desert-shore desalination plants. Some recent installations make use of solar energy, which is freely available in hot, dry countries, but this technology is still being perfected.